

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

The Story of Ayomide

*“I may fall, I may get tired, I may lose myself for a while.
But somehow, I always find a way to keep going.”*

CONTENTS

1. Where It All Began
2. The Boy From Igunshin
3. My Mother
4. Eight Children
5. The Accident
6. The Father I Didn't Know
7. The Work That Kept Me Going
8. The Years Nobody Saw
9. Another Chance
10. Becoming a Graduate
11. Love
12. Who I Became
13. The Boy Who Kept Going

CHAPTER ONE

Where It All Began

There are some stories that begin with a big moment.

Mine didn't.

Mine began quietly, in a place called Igunshin.

That was where I was born and raised. It was where I learned what work meant before I was old enough to understand what life really was. It was where I went to school, played football, got into trouble, laughed with friends, and slowly became the person I am today.

I attended Bright Future Nursery and Primary School in Igunshin. Later, I attended Igunshin Community Grammar School, where I started my secondary school education and spent my JSS1 and JSS2 years.

Eventually, I changed schools to Adaja Community Grammar School, where I completed my secondary education and wrote my first and only WAEC.

I wrote my WAEC once, in 2014.

I didn't have to sit for it again.

Looking back, that may seem like just another detail in my educational journey, but at the time, I was simply trying to get through school and figure out what life had in store for me.

My childhood was not the kind where everything was handed to you.

My father was a farmer.

My mother was a tailor and fashion designer.

And our home was not always peaceful.

There were eight of us children growing up together, each with different personalities, different dreams and different ways of seeing life.

Growing up, it sometimes felt like work and work.

If you didn't go to the farm, you didn't feel entitled to sleep.

If you didn't work, you didn't feel entitled to eat.

Even when you were sick, there were times when the expectation was still to work.

At that age, I didn't understand why life had to be that way.

I only knew that it was the way things were.

Looking back now, I realise that those years were teaching me something I would need much later in life.

They were teaching me how to endure.

How to keep moving when I was tired.

How to survive when things were not comfortable.

How to do what needed to be done even when I didn't feel like doing it.

I also grew up knowing very little about my father's side of the family.

I knew that some of them were outside the country. I knew they existed, but that was about as far as my connection with them went.

And sometimes I would think about it.

If you don't know someone, or you have never met them, how are you supposed to run to them when you need help?

How do you ask for assistance from people who don't really know you?

That was one of the realities of my childhood.

I never really knew my father's side of the family, and I knew very little about my mother's family too. My father did not really want us relating with some of his relatives, partly because of things he had experienced in his own childhood.

So, for the most part, we grew up as our own little world.

Of everyone at home, I was closest to my mother.

And somewhere inside that family was a boy who was already learning how to hustle.

I had been hustling in one way or another since nursery school.

I didn't know that word would eventually become such a big part of my life.

I only knew that if I wanted something, I had to find a way.

If something needed to be done, I had to do it.

If life became difficult, I had to keep moving.

I didn't know what was waiting for me.

I didn't know how much pain I would experience.

I didn't know how many times I would have to start again.

I didn't know that one day I would look back at that boy and realise just how much he had survived.

All I knew was that I was from Igunshin.

I didn't know what was waiting for me, or how many times life would ask me to start again. I only knew that I was a boy from Igunshin, learning—little by little—how to survive whatever came next.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

CHAPTER TWO

The Boy From Igunshin

If you asked me to describe the boy I was growing up, I would probably say I was calm, quiet, playful, serious and stubborn.

I could be very quiet, but that didn't mean I wasn't having fun.

I loved football.

The funny thing is, I wasn't even very good at it.

But that never stopped me.

Football was part of childhood. We played because we enjoyed it. We ran around, argued about who was better, laughed at each other and went home when it was time.

Those were simple days.

There was also our group.

We called ourselves "Magor," which basically meant don't dull.

We were young, restless and always looking for something to do.

During Christmas and holiday periods, when people came back to the village, we would chase girls around and generally behave like boys who had nothing more important to worry about.

Looking back, some of those things make me laugh now.

I wasn't always the innocent child either.

There were times I stole money from my parents.

There were times I took meat from the soup without permission.

Small things that felt like serious missions at the time.

But those moments were part of growing up.

One of the people I was closest to during those years was my friend Shileola, whom we called Merit.

We did things together.

We hustled together.

We experienced parts of childhood together.

I think I started hustling very early in life.

Even from nursery school, there was already something in me that made me want to find a way.

Maybe that is partly why I became comfortable with being alone.

I learned early that you cannot always depend on having someone beside you.

Sometimes you have to figure things out yourself.

Even though I became comfortable with solitude, I remained close to my siblings and especially to my mother.

My childhood wasn't perfect.

There were struggles at home.

There was work.

There were family issues.

There were moments I didn't understand.

But there was also laughter.

There were friends.

There was football.

There were mischievous moments.

There were memories that, even now, I wouldn't trade.

Sometimes I think about that boy and wonder whether he would recognise the man I became.

He could never have imagined the years ahead: leaving school, working to survive, losing his mother, living through seasons of hunger and uncertainty, and eventually returning to school to become a graduate.

He was simply a boy from Igunshin. He didn't know the future. He only knew how to live one day at a time.

Maybe that was the first lesson life gave me: you don't always need to know where you are going before you take the next step. Sometimes, you just have to keep moving.

CHAPTER THREE

My Mother

My mother was one of the calmest people I have ever known.

She was gentle, loving, caring and supportive. She had a kind heart, and even when life was difficult, she rarely allowed her problems to change the way she treated the people around her.

My mother was actually the kind of person you could put water in her mouth and tell her, “Don’t swallow it. I’m going to Abuja, and when I come back, that water must still be in your mouth.”

And somehow, you would return and find her still calm.

That was how cool and how calm she was.

She was not the type to shout unnecessarily or look for trouble. She had a way of carrying herself that made you understand that peace was simply part of who she was.

But don’t let that calmness fool you.

My mother could deal with me when I deserved it.

Whenever she warned me about something and I went against her warning, or whenever I went out and came back home late without doing whatever work I was supposed to do at home, she could wait until midnight just to deal with me.

And sometimes, the weapon was the broom.

Yes, my mother could beat me with a broom.

Looking back now, it makes me laugh.

But at that time, it wasn’t funny at all.

The funniest part was what happened the next morning.

You dared not squeeze your face around her.

You had to behave yourself like nothing happened.

And, of course, you wouldn't tell your siblings what happened.

That was our little secret.

She could beat you at night and still be your mother in the morning.

She could discipline you and still make you feel loved.

That was my mother.

She was a tailor and fashion designer, and she worked hard to take care of us.

There were times when she would go without eating just so her children could eat and be happy. She had her own struggles, but she didn't always allow us to see how much she was carrying.

She was the kind of woman who could be suffering and still worry about whether her children were okay.

I was very close to her.

We were almost like five and six.

She called me Ayomide, and I called her Mom.

There was something about the way she called my name that I still remember.

Even now, when I think about her, I don't only remember the difficult moments.

I remember her calmness.

I remember her laughter.

I remember her discipline.

I remember the way she cared.

And I remember how much she loved her children.

One of the memories that has stayed with me happened when I was working as a storekeeper in Ondo.

My mother tried calling me but couldn't reach me.

Instead of simply assuming I was fine, she travelled all the way from Igunshin to Ondo just to see me.

That moment meant a lot to me.

She didn't need a big reason.

She just needed to know that her son was okay.

That was the kind of mother she was.

But life eventually became cruel to her.

My mother became very sick.

She became blind and eventually reached a point where she could no longer do many of the things she had always done for herself and for us.

Watching her become that way was painful.

This was a woman who had spent her life working, caring for her children and putting other people before herself.

Now she needed people to care for her.

I hated seeing her suffer.

I still wish I had been there more.

I still wish I could have done more.

And one of the things I struggle with most is that I wasn't there when she died.

There are some losses you don't simply get over.

You learn to live with them.

You carry them differently as the years pass.

I graduated in 2026, and one of the first thoughts that came to my mind was that I wished my mother could have been there to see it.

I wished she could have seen the boy she raised become a graduate.

I wished I could have looked at her and said,

“Mom, I finally did it.”

But life doesn’t always give us the ending we want.

She didn’t get to see that day.

Still, everything she gave me remains.

Her love.

Her discipline.

Her calmness.

Her sacrifices.

Her advice.

Her strength.

And the memories.

I still miss her.

Maybe I always will.

But whenever I think about my mother, I don’t only think about the woman I lost.

I think about the woman who raised me.

The woman who could be so calm you could trust her with water in her mouth until you returned from Abuja.

The woman who could wait until midnight with a broom because her stubborn son had disobeyed her.

The woman who would still expect him to behave normally the next morning.

The woman who travelled from Igunshin to Ondo just because she couldn't reach her son.

The woman who gave so much of herself to her children.

That was my mother.

And before she became the person I would spend years missing, she was simply Mom.

My Mom.

And I was her Ayomide.

CHAPTER FOUR

Eight Children

Growing up, I was one of eight children.

We came from the same father but different mothers.

My father had three wives. The first wife had two children, my mother had four children, and the last wife had two children.

That made eight of us in total.

I was the fourth child and the first son from my mother.

Growing up in a polygamous family was not always easy.

There were different personalities, different mothers, different expectations and, at times, very little peace in the home.

But despite everything, we were still siblings.

We grew up together.

We fought.

We played.

We annoyed each other.

We supported each other.

And, like most families, we had our own crazy moments.

My eldest brother is Kolawole.

He attended Rufus Giwa Polytechnic and later worked for a company in Ore. Eventually, he returned to farming, following the path of our father. He is now married with four children.

My second brother is Solomon.

He stopped his education after WAEC. He is married and has one child.

My third sibling is Imoleayo.

After completing WAEC, she went into nursing training. She has one child and is not married.

Then there is me.

I am the fourth child.

My own journey took me from secondary school, to an admission to study Nutrition and Dietetics, to dropping out, working different jobs, starting again, and eventually studying Educational Technology at Tai Solarin University of Education.

Then there is my younger sibling, the fifth child, who stopped at secondary school and is a twin.

The sixth child is currently studying Economics and was admitted in 2025.

The seventh child stopped at secondary school, is married and has one child.

The eighth child also stopped at secondary school.

For a long time, our family wasn't exactly the picture of peace.

There were struggles.

There were misunderstandings.

There were things we experienced differently because we were raised by different mothers.

But life has a strange way of bringing people closer after taking something important away.

When my mom died, something changed among us.

We began to come together more.

We started understanding each other differently.

We became more united.

Today, despite everything we have been through and despite the fact that some of us can still be a little crazy in our own ways, there is love between us.

We have all taken different paths.

Some went further in school.

Some stopped early.

Some got married.

Some had children.

Some are still trying to figure life out.

And then there is me, still trying to become everything I believe I can become.

When I look at my siblings, I see different versions of the same struggle.

We didn't all have the same opportunities.

We didn't all make the same choices.

We didn't all experience our childhood in exactly the same way.

But we share something that cannot be changed:

We are family.

Eight children from the same father, different mothers, different stories, different struggles—and somehow, we are still here.

And perhaps that is another part of my story that I have learned to appreciate.

Sometimes family isn't perfect.

Sometimes family is complicated.

Sometimes family hurts.

But sometimes, after everything, family finds its way back to each other.

And I am grateful that we did.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Accident

There are some moments in life that divide your story into two parts: before it happened and after it happened.

For me, the accident at Ajue is one of those moments.

It was the same year I lost my mother. I was already carrying a kind of pain I did not know how to explain, and then life gave me another experience that could easily have taken me away too.

That morning started like any other morning.

I called my dad on the phone and told him I would be coming to Igunshin to see him and bring him some fuel. I wanted to do something useful for him, something small, but something that would make his work a little easier.

When I got there, I didn't meet him. He had already gone to work.

He told me to drop the fuel at home.

Before we ended the call, he prayed for me.

It was a simple conversation. Nothing about it sounded like a goodbye. Nothing suggested that only a few hours later, I would be involved in one of the worst accidents of my life.

I left and continued my journey.

I was travelling to Benin for a church programme. I had my bag with me, and inside that bag was my Bible.

I remember sitting there with the journey ahead of me, not knowing that my life was about to change in a matter of seconds.

Then I saw it.

A big truck was coming directly in front of us.

Everything happened so quickly.

Even now, I cannot explain why I did what I did next. Something—something I still cannot put into words—made me put on my glasses.

That is one of the last things I remember before everything went blank.

It felt like I slept off.

Not long after, I opened my eyes.

I was on the ground.

For a few seconds, I didn't understand where I was.

I looked around me.

There was confusion everywhere.

People were moving around. Some were asking questions. Some were trying to help. Some were looking at the wreckage.

And then I saw the blood.

Some of the passengers were lying on the ground, covered in blood.

I was shocked.

I looked at myself.

I touched my body.

I checked my arms.

I checked my legs.

I couldn't find anything.

No wound.

No broken bone.

No visible injury.

Nothing.

People were tapping me and asking if I was hurt.

“Are you okay?”

“Are you injured?”

“Who can we call?”

I was probably as confused as they were.

How could I have been inside that vehicle and come out without an injury?

The car was destroyed so badly that they had to cut it apart before they could get the driver out.

There were six people in the vehicle, including the driver.

Only two of us survived.

The other survivor was a woman. She sustained injuries.

I did not.

I still struggle to explain that.

Sometimes when I tell people about it, I hear myself saying the words, but even I find them difficult to believe.

I survived a terrible accident without a wound.

But surviving the accident was only the beginning of the story.

They eventually found my phone.

Thankfully, I was able to unlock it. Someone used it to call my dad.

I can only imagine what it must have felt like for him to receive that call.

Just that morning, I had called him.

Just that morning, I had told him I was bringing him fuel.

Just that morning, he had prayed for me before we ended the call.

And now someone else was calling him about an accident.

My father was devastated.

He became angry at himself. He was frustrated, frightened and overwhelmed by the possibility that he could lose me.

He told one of my brothers:

“He just left, and he said he brought me some fuel.”

Then he asked something that has stayed with me ever since:

“Does that mean this will be the last time I’ll ever receive a gift from my son, or even hear his voice?”

That sentence was heavy.

Very heavy.

I think sometimes we don’t realise the meaning of an ordinary moment until we are afraid we might never experience another one.

The fuel I was carrying was just fuel.

The phone call was just a phone call.

His prayer was just a prayer.

Until suddenly, they could all have become the last things we ever shared.

My father came to the hospital.

That was another moment I will never forget.

I was discharged that same day and brought back home. He took care of me and stayed around until I got better.

The accident changed something in the way I saw my father. Seeing his fear that day made me realise that, whatever the distance between us had been, he loved me and did not want to lose me. What happened between us after that belongs to another chapter.

I don't know what would have happened if I had been seriously injured. I don't know what would have happened if I had not survived.

I only know what happened.

I survived.

And because I survived, I have asked myself the same question many times:

Why?

Why did I walk away without an injury when other people didn't?

Why was I spared?

Why did I wake up on that ground when my life could have ended inside that vehicle?

Was it because I was travelling to church?

Was it my faith?

Was it the prayers my mother had prayed for me?

Was it simply God's plan?

I don't know.

Maybe I never will.

But I believe there is something powerful about surviving something you were never supposed to survive.

It makes you look at life differently.

Every time I remember that day, I look up to God and think about the purpose behind it.

If there was a reason I was kept alive, I want to discover it.

If there was a purpose, I want my life to fulfil it.

I don't want to waste the life I was given.

I have already lost my mother. I have already lost years. I have already experienced poverty, rejection, disappointment and moments when I didn't know whether I would make it to the next day.

But that accident taught me something I could never have learned from a classroom:

I am still here.

And as long as I am still here, my story is not finished.

Maybe I don't have everything figured out.

Maybe I don't know exactly where my life is going.

But every time I remember Ajue, I remember that I was given another morning.

Another opportunity.

Another chance.

And perhaps that is the reason I keep going.

There must be a reason I'm still here.

Maybe I haven't discovered it yet.

Maybe my life is still becoming the answer.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

CHAPTER SIX

The Father I Didn't Know

For a long time, I didn't have the relationship with my father that I have today.

Growing up, I felt that he wasn't responsible in the way I needed him to be.

There were things I went through without him.

There were moments when I needed support and learned to find my own way.

Because of that, there was a distance between us.

But people can change.

My father eventually found his way back to Jesus.

Something changed in him.

He became different.

He acknowledged some of the things he had done wrong and began trying to make amends.

The man I once felt distant from gradually became someone I could talk to.

Someone I could call.

Someone who would listen.

During university, there were times when my father sent money for my school fees without me begging him for it.

Those moments meant more to me than the money itself.

Because I understood what they represented.

They represented change.

They represented a father who was trying.

Today, when things become difficult, my father is one of the people I call.

Sometimes I just need to rant.

Sometimes I need advice.

Sometimes I need someone to pray for me.

He listens.

He advises me.

He checks on me.

He calls to know how I am doing.

He wants me to become a better man.

I don't usually ask people for help.

So when I call my father because I need something, he understands that I probably really need it.

That relationship wasn't built overnight.

It came after years of distance, misunderstanding and change.

I can't erase the things I experienced as a child.

But I also don't want to spend the rest of my life refusing to recognise the man my father eventually became.

Life taught me that people are capable of changing.

Sometimes, the person you thought you would never understand can become the person you eventually find yourself calling when life becomes difficult.

My father and I have come a long way.

And today, I am grateful for that.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Work That Kept Me Going

Work has always been a major part of my story.

I have done different kinds of work.

I worked as a barman in a lounge inside Igbinedion University, Okada.

I worked as a storekeeper in Ondo.

I worked as a filling station attendant in Ondo.

I worked at a gas station in Lagos.

I worked as a labourer.

None of those jobs was glamorous.

But they were honest.

And when you are trying to survive, sometimes you don't have the luxury of choosing what looks impressive.

You do what is available.

You work.

You get paid.

You eat.

You continue.

Some people may look at certain jobs and feel they are beneath them.

I never had that luxury.

For me, work was survival.

Work was how I kept myself moving.

Work was how I learned to depend on myself.

It taught me discipline.

It taught me patience.

It taught me that no honest work should make you ashamed.

There were times I was tired.

There were times I wanted something better.

There were times I wondered whether I was making progress at all.

But every job gave me something.

Sometimes it was money.

Sometimes it was experience.

Sometimes it was simply another day survived.

And maybe that is why I have never been ashamed of where I started.

I know what it means to work when nobody is watching.

I know what it means to wake up and go out because there is something you have to do.

I know what it means to keep working even when the future doesn't look clear.

Those years shaped me.

They made me understand that survival is not always beautiful.

Sometimes survival is sweaty.

Sometimes it is tiring.

Sometimes it is lonely.

Sometimes it means doing work nobody notices.

But if that work keeps you alive and moving toward something better, it matters.

Every job I did became part of the road that eventually led me back to school.

I didn't know it then.

I was simply trying to survive.

But sometimes survival is the first step toward rebuilding your life.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Years Nobody Saw

There are years of my life that are difficult to explain.

Between around 2017 and 2020, my life was difficult and confusing in ways that only God can truly answer.

From the outside, people might have thought I was simply working and living.

But inside, I was struggling.

At one point, while working as a labourer in Lagos, I lived in an uncompleted duplex for months.

It was not the kind of place anyone dreams of living.

But at that point in my life, dreams had become secondary.

Survival came first.

There were times when I had very little money.

There were times when I ate once a day.

There were moments when I didn't even feel like showing myself in public.

My mental and emotional state became very bad.

I questioned my purpose.

I questioned my life.

I wondered why I was going through so much.

There were moments when the pain became so heavy that I attempted to take my own life.

Twice.

I don't write that because I want sympathy.

I write it because it is part of my story.

There was a point where I didn't know how to carry everything I was carrying.

I had experienced rejection.

Anger.

Hatred.

Disappointment.

Poverty.

Loss.

I had come too far, but somehow I still felt like I wasn't going anywhere.

Yet something inside me kept fighting.

One of the things that kept coming to my mind was how far I had already come.

I had survived too much to simply disappear.

I also thought about my younger sibling, Deborah.

I love her deeply.

There is something about her that reminds me of my mother.

Maybe that was another reason I couldn't completely give up.

I kept telling myself that I would not stop until I got what I wanted.

I had no reason to doubt myself.

I didn't know exactly how I would get there.

I didn't know how long it would take.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

But I knew I didn't want my story to end in that place.

Those years are some of the years nobody saw.

People saw me.

But they didn't always see what was happening inside me.

They didn't see the nights.

They didn't see the fear.

They didn't see the emptiness.

They didn't see how many times I had to convince myself to keep going.

But I survived those years.

And that matters.

Because sometimes surviving a season is an achievement in itself.

CHAPTER NINE

Another Chance

In 2016, I gained admission to study Nutrition and Dietetics at Rufus Giwa Polytechnic.

I thought I was finally moving forward.

But life had other plans.

In 2017, I dropped out.

It wasn't because I didn't want an education.

I simply didn't have the support system I needed.

Financially and otherwise, I was struggling.

So I left school and went to Lagos to work and save money, hoping that one day I would be able to return.

For a while, I didn't know whether that day would ever come.

But something inside me refused to completely let go of education.

Around April 2022, despite having little or no money, I decided to take JAMB again.

It was another risk.

Another attempt.

Another chance.

And eventually, I gained admission to study Educational Technology at Tai Solarin University of Education.

I had another opportunity.

But getting admitted was one thing.

Staying in school was another.

My 100 level was horrible.

It was difficult.

There were moments when I wanted to drop out again.

I knew what it felt like to leave school once, and I was afraid of repeating the same story.

That same year, my father became seriously ill.

That frightened me deeply.

I was scared that I could become an orphan.

I didn't want to lose another parent.

I was already carrying the pain of losing my mother.

I didn't know how I would survive losing my father too.

But somehow, I continued.

There were people who helped me along the way.

There was God.

There were my father's prayers and support.

There were people like Abu.

There was Nikki.

Nikki supported me in small but meaningful ways and reminded me that I shouldn't give up.

The message behind those moments was simple:

They didn't give birth to me to give up.

That stayed with me.

I also made sacrifices.

At one point, I sold my iPhone 12 Pro Max to pay school fees and handle other expenses.

I eventually found myself using an iPhone 6.

To someone else, that might have looked like a downgrade.

To me, it was a decision.

I was choosing my future.

I had already lost one opportunity.

I wasn't going to casually lose another.

So I kept going.

Semester after semester.

Level after level.

Problem after problem.

Sometimes I didn't know how the next payment would come.

Sometimes I didn't know how I would handle the next challenge.

But somehow, something always happened.

Another opportunity.

Another person.

Another sacrifice.

Another prayer.

Another reason to continue.

And slowly, the boy who once dropped out of school was getting closer to becoming a graduate.

CHAPTER TEN

Becoming a Graduate

There is a particular feeling that comes when you finally reach the end of something you once thought you might never finish.

For me, that feeling came during my final semester.

I had gone through years of uncertainty to reach that point.

Then, even at the very end, life still tested me.

I was seriously sick on the day of my final paper.

I could have stayed in the hospital.

I could have said I wasn't going.

But somehow, I went from the hospital to the examination hall.

I wrote my final paper.

And when it was over, something inside me changed.

I had finished.

After everything, I had finished.

When I finally became a graduate, my first thought was:

"So I'm finally a graduate now."

It sounds simple.

But that sentence carried years of my life.

It carried Igunshin, the work, the dropout, the hunger, the uncompleted building, my mother's memory, my father's support, the people who helped me, the sacrifices I made, and every time I had told myself to keep going.

I looked at the journey and realised that graduation wasn't just about getting a certificate.

It was proof that I had survived the journey.

I didn't finish because everything was easy.

I finished because I kept going even when it wasn't.

And for that, I am grateful to God.

I wish my mother had been alive to see it.

I wish she could have watched me walk across that stage.

I wish I could have heard her call me Ayomide.

But she wasn't there.

So I carried her memory with me.

I carried everything she gave me.

And when I finally became a graduate, I knew she was part of the story too.

This wasn't just my victory.

It was also a reminder of where I came from.

A reminder that the boy who once thought his education was over eventually found another road.

A reminder that sometimes the first opportunity failing does not mean every opportunity is gone.

Sometimes you get another chance.

And when that chance comes, you have to fight for it.

I did.

And I made it.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Love

I have not had many serious relationships in my life.

But there was one person who became different from everyone else.

I met her through her friend about four or five years ago.

At first, I didn't know what the relationship would become.

But the more I got to know her, the more I realised that she was different.

I believed she was loyal.

She was kind.

She was full of love.

And I believed she never cheated on me.

She became the first girl I truly took seriously.

She was probably the first person with whom I started the journey of genuinely understanding what it meant to be with someone I truly loved.

I loved her with the depth of my soul.

But I didn't know how to show her that back then.

Maybe I was afraid.

I was afraid of losing her.

I was afraid of showing her just how much she had become a part of me, because sometimes when someone becomes too important to you, the fear of losing them becomes just as strong as the love you have for them.

All I wanted was to see her happy.

I wanted to protect her.

I wanted to keep her close.

I wanted her to feel safe with me.

I wanted to be someone she could depend on.

But I failed at some of those things then.

Something went wrong between us around 2022 or 2023, and eventually, we separated.

Looking back, I blamed myself for the lack of communication.

I blamed myself for losing her.

For years, I carried those feelings with me.

The pain didn't simply disappear because we were no longer together.

I still loved her.

I still wanted her back.

I tried my best to find my way back to her, but it wasn't easy.

Sometimes love can remain in your heart even when the person you love is no longer beside you.

And that was what happened to me.

Years passed.

Life continued.

I changed.

She changed.

We both lived separate lives.

But somewhere inside me, the feelings never completely disappeared.

Then, during my sign-out, she reached out to congratulate me.

I don't think either of us knew exactly what that moment would become.

But that was where our love story began again.

It felt like life had somehow given us another opportunity.

A second chance.

But this time, she was different.

She had grown into a different version of herself.

She had grown.

She had changed.

And sometimes, I found myself trying to understand this version of the woman I had once known.

But even with all the changes, I still believed in her.

I still trusted her.

And the feelings I have for her keep getting stronger every single day.

I don't know exactly what the future holds for us.

I don't know where our story will eventually lead.

But whatever the future holds, I want to be there.

I want to be able to look back one day and tell her:

"It was hard. It wasn't easy. But I eventually put that ring on your finger."

Because, in my heart, she deserves it.

I don't want to stop loving her.

I want to keep protecting her.

When life becomes hard, rough and tough, I want her to be the person I can comfortably come home to.

When life is sweet, I want her to be the first person I share the good news with.

I want to build a life where home isn't just a place.

Home is her.

Coming back to her feels like a blessing I never want to lose again.

And perhaps one of the biggest changes in me is that I no longer see love as a battle over who is right or who has more control.

Sometimes loving someone means putting your pride down.

Sometimes it means choosing to meet the person you love where they are.

Bringing myself down to her standards, not because I have lost myself, but because I want her to feel loved and taken care of, is something I now see differently.

I want to love her properly.

I want to take care of her.

I want her to feel safe.

I want her to know that she doesn't have to question whether she matters to me.

I have already experienced what it feels like to lose someone I loved.

I know what those years felt like.

I know what regret feels like.

And I don't ever want to take love for granted again.

Maybe our story will not be perfect.

Maybe there will still be difficult days.

Maybe we will still misunderstand each other sometimes.

But if life gives us the opportunity to continue this journey, I want to do it differently.

I want to communicate.

I want to listen.

I want to love without being afraid of showing how much I care.

Because this time, I don't want fear to make me hide the depth of what I feel.

I loved her then.

I love her now.

And whatever tomorrow brings, a part of me will always be grateful that life gave our story another beginning.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Who I Became

I used to be a very hard guy.

Life made me a soft guy.

But being soft does not mean I became weak.

It means life changed the way I see people, love, friendship, family and even myself.

There was a time when I wanted to be unreachable.

I didn't want people to think they had access to me all the time.

I wanted to live a life of peace and silence, where nobody could constantly disturb me or make demands of me.

I wanted my own space.

I wanted peace.

But somehow, life made me soft.

Life made me feel at ease.

I became someone who genuinely loved helping people.

I have helped people even when I didn't have much myself.

I have given to people when I didn't even have enough to give.

I have come through for people who, looking back, probably didn't deserve the sacrifices I made for them.

I have sacrificed.

I have put my own life aside to attend to other people.

Sometimes, I gave people a good place in my life when they never gave me the same place in theirs.

I did it because that was who I was.

I cared.

I wanted people around me to be okay.

I wanted to be useful.

I wanted to be the person someone could call when things were difficult.

But life teaches you lessons.

Sometimes, it teaches them painfully.

There came a point where I became tired of people.

I didn't want to associate myself with anyone.

I didn't want unnecessary friendships.

I didn't want people having constant access to me.

I didn't want to keep giving pieces of myself to people who didn't understand the value of what I was giving.

Even someone I always called my brother showed me that he wasn't worth the trust I gave him.

He betrayed me so many times.

And those experiences changed the way I looked at people.

They made me more careful.

They made me more distant.

They made me understand that not everyone you call a friend deserves access to your life.

Not everyone you help will appreciate it.

Not everyone you sacrifice for will sacrifice for you.

And not everyone you call family will treat you like family.

There were also people I felt were against me.

People who talked about me behind my back but didn't have the confidence to say those things to my face.

People I felt were jealous because I was figuring things out on my own without involving them.

People who seemed to turn life into a competition with me, even though I didn't have the time or interest to compete with anyone.

There were even moments when I felt people tried to blackmail me.

For a long time, those things bothered me.

But eventually, I realised something.

I'm still here.

I'm still breathing.

I'm still moving.

I'm still building my life.

And I'm not afraid of anyone.

I know I have someone up there watching over me every second.

That gives me a different kind of confidence.

So whatever people say about me, whatever they think about me, whatever they say behind my back or whatever they choose to make up about my life, it is no longer my concern.

Because their opinions don't determine how I live my life.

Their jealousy doesn't determine my future.

Their words don't decide who I become.

I have my own journey to complete.

I have my own dreams to chase.

I have a life to build.

And I don't have time to spend my life trying to prove myself to people who have already decided what they want to believe about me.

But that's life.

And as painful as those experiences have been, they don't completely change who I am.

I still want to help people.

I still believe in doing good.

I still believe that when you have the ability to help someone who genuinely deserves it, you should.

The difference now is that I have learned that kindness also needs boundaries.

I don't have to destroy myself to prove that I care.

I don't have to empty myself for everyone.

I don't have to give everyone access to me.

I can love people from a distance.

I can wish people well without allowing them into every part of my life.

I can help without expecting anything in return.

Because I have learned something important:

My reward is in the hands of God, not in the hands of human beings.

I don't help people because I expect them to repay me.

I don't sacrifice because I want applause.

I don't give because I want someone to owe me forever.

I do it because, despite everything life has taught me, there is still a part of me that wants to see people okay.

Maybe that's the soft side of me that life created.

The boy I used to be wanted to be hard enough that nobody could hurt him.

The man I became learned that being soft could also be a strength.

But now I understand something else too.

I can be soft without being available to everyone.

I can be kind without being foolish.

I can love people without losing myself.

I can help people without allowing them to use me.

And I can protect my peace without becoming a bad person.

I have lost people.

I have been disappointed.

I have been betrayed.

I have given more than I received.

But I don't want those experiences to turn me into someone I am not.

I still want to be a good man.

I still want to help the people who genuinely deserve it.

I still want to be there for the people I love.

I just don't want to lose myself while doing it.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

Because after everything I have survived, I have finally understood that my life matters too.

My peace matters.

My time matters.

My heart matters.

And sometimes, the strongest thing you can do is simply step back, become unreachable for a while, and protect the life you are trying so hard to build.

I am still the soft guy life created.

But now, I know how to protect the softness.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Boy Who Kept Going

When I look back at my life, I don't see a straight line.

I see a road with turns I never expected.

I see a boy from Igunshin who grew up learning that work was part of life. A boy who played football even though he wasn't very good at it, laughed with his friends, got into trouble, loved his mother deeply, and thought mostly about the day in front of him.

I see a young man who learned to hustle, who left school because circumstances became too difficult, and who worked whatever honest job he could find. I see the labourer who lived in an uncompleted building. I see the days when money was scarce and food was not guaranteed. I see the years when people could look at me and never know how much I was carrying inside.

I see the loss of my mother.

I see the accident at Ajue.

I see my father standing on the other side of fear, wondering whether he might lose his son.

I see the years when our relationship slowly changed.

I see the first opportunity I lost in education, and then the second chance I decided to create for myself.

I see the JAMB form, the admission to Tai Solarin University of Education, the difficult beginning, my father's illness, the people who helped me, and the sacrifices I made to stay in school.

I see the phone I sold because my education mattered more to me than keeping it.

I see the iPhone 6 that replaced it.

To someone else, it might have looked like a downgrade. To me, it was a decision about what mattered most.

And then I see the final semester.

I see myself going from the hospital to the examination hall because I wanted to finish what I had started.

I see the moment the final paper ended.

And I hear the thought that came into my mind:

“So I’m finally a graduate now.”

Those words were simple, but they carried years inside them.

They carried failure and another chance.

They carried hunger and hard work.

They carried grief, fear, sacrifice and prayer.

They carried the people who believed in me and the people who did not.

Most of all, they carried the boy who kept going.

Graduation did not erase everything that came before it.

It did not bring my mother back.

It did not return the years I lost.

It did not make every wound disappear.

But it gave me something I had once wondered whether I would ever have: proof that a difficult chapter does not have to be the final chapter.

My mother is still part of that moment.

I wish she had been there to watch me walk across the stage. I wish I could have heard her call me Ayomide and told her, “Mom, I finally did it.”

She wasn’t there, but everything she gave me came with me.

Her love.

Her discipline.

Her sacrifices.

Her calmness.

Her memory.

My father is part of the story too.

Our relationship was not always what I wanted it to be, but people can change. He changed, I changed, and somewhere along the way we found a relationship I am grateful for today.

Love became another chapter of becoming.

I learned what it means to care deeply, what fear can do to communication, what it feels like to lose someone you love, and what it means when life gives two people another opportunity to find their way back to each other.

I don’t know exactly what the future of that relationship will be.

But I know what kind of man I want to be in it: honest, present, communicative, protective without being controlling, and willing to listen.

Life also changed the way I treat people.

I used to think being hard would protect me.

Instead, life made me softer.

But softness taught me something that hardness never could: I can care about people without giving everyone access to me. I

can be kind without being foolish. I can help without destroying myself. I can love without losing myself.

Those lessons came through disappointment as much as they came through love.

I have trusted people who disappointed me. I have given more than I received. I have experienced betrayal and moments when I felt misunderstood.

But I don't want those experiences to turn me into someone bitter.

I want boundaries, not bitterness.

I want wisdom, not suspicion of everyone.

I want peace without becoming cold.

Then there is Ajue.

I still think about that accident.

The vehicle was destroyed. Six people were inside, including the driver. Only two of us survived, and I walked away without a visible injury.

I still don't have a complete explanation for why.

I believe in God, so I have often asked what that survival means.

Was there a purpose?

Was there something I was still meant to do?

I don't pretend to know the answer.

Maybe I will spend the rest of my life discovering it.

Maybe the answer is not one dramatic assignment, but the way I choose to live every day.

That question has become part of my reason for moving forward.

I have been given another morning more times than I ever deserved to count.

So I want to use those mornings well.

I want to build a life my family can benefit from.

I want to become a man my family can depend on.

I want to give without constantly checking whether I have enough.

I want to make the people I love proud.

I want to build things that outlive the difficult seasons that produced me.

And I still want to understand the purpose behind everything I have survived.

But I also know something now that I did not know as a boy:

I do not need to have my whole life figured out before I take the next step.

That may be the lesson hidden inside this entire story.

I thought I needed to know where I was going.

Life taught me to keep moving even when I could not see the whole road.

I thought failing meant the end.

Life taught me that sometimes failure is simply a change of direction.

I thought being hard would keep me safe.

Life taught me that softness can be strength when it is protected by wisdom and boundaries.

I thought losing people meant I would never be whole again.

Life taught me that grief can become part of you without becoming all of you.

I thought the worst chapter might be the end of my story.

Life taught me to turn the page.

So when I think about the boy I used to be, I don't feel ashamed of him.

I am proud of him.

He didn't do everything right.

He made mistakes.

He got into trouble.

He stole meat from the soup.

He was stubborn.

He sometimes made choices he would later regret.

But he kept learning.

He became the boy who worked.

The boy who loved football.

The boy who loved his mother.

The boy who lost his mother.

The boy who dropped out.

The boy who went to Lagos to work.

The boy who lived in an uncompleted building.

The boy who sometimes ate once a day.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

The boy who reached a point where life felt too heavy to carry.

The boy who found reasons to stay.

The boy who tried again.

The boy who sacrificed what he had for another opportunity.

The boy who walked from a hospital into an examination hall.

The boy who became a graduate.

The boy who learned to love differently.

The boy who learned that kindness needs boundaries.

That boy is me.

And I am proud of him.

Not because his life was perfect.

Not because he never fell.

Not because everything worked out exactly as planned.

I am proud because he kept getting back up.

Sometimes slowly.

Sometimes with tears.

Sometimes angry.

Sometimes with almost nothing except faith.

But he got back up.

And that is what I want this story to leave behind.

Not a promise that life will become easy.

Not a claim that every struggle has a neat explanation.

Not even a guarantee that every dream will come true exactly as imagined.

Just this:

A bad chapter does not have to be your final sentence.

If you have failed, you can begin again.

If you have lost years, you can still build new ones.

If you have been disappointed, you can learn without becoming bitter.

If you have been knocked down, you can take another step.

If all you can do today is survive today, then survive today.

Tomorrow can be dealt with when it comes.

I know what it feels like to think that life has already decided your ending.

I know what it feels like to look at your circumstances and wonder whether anything will ever change.

I also know that sometimes the next page arrives in a form you never expected: a job, a person, an opportunity, a sacrifice, a prayer, a second attempt, or simply another morning.

You do not have to know the whole road.

You only have to take the next honest step.

From Igunshin to here, I have learned that survival can become rebuilding, and rebuilding can become a life you once thought was impossible.

I am still dreaming.

I am still learning.

I am still becoming.

I am still trying to understand why I survived what I survived.

And I am still going.

This is not the end of my story.

It is only the end of the part I have chosen to tell here.

The boy who began this journey is still somewhere inside me.

When life gets hard, I remember him.

I remember where he came from.

I remember what he survived.

I remember my mother.

I remember the people who helped me.

And I remember that I have made it through days I once thought
I could not survive.

So I will keep moving.

I will keep dreaming.

I will keep trying.

I will keep becoming.

Because the goal was never to have a life without storms.

The goal was to learn how to keep walking when the storm
comes.

To the boy I once was:

Thank you for carrying the story this far.

Thank you for trying again.

Thank you for keeping the dream alive.

And to whoever reads these pages:

If your story is still being written, don't let one difficult chapter
convince you that the book is over.

Keep going.

THE BOY WHO KEPT GOING

Sometimes the person you are fighting so hard to save is you.

This is my story.

This is where I came from.

This is what I survived.

This is who I became.

And this is the boy who kept going.

He is still going.

I am still going.

And as long as there is breath in me, the story continues.

NEVER GO BACK TO EAT YOUR OWN VOMIT.